

IB Music Course Book

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Table of contents

Preface	1
Assessment Guidance	3
Requirements that apply to every component	3
Exploring Music in Context	4
Experimenting with Music	7
Presenting Music	9
The Contemporary Music Maker (HL only)	11
Assessment submission checklist (all components)	13
 Exploring Music in Context	 15
Exploring: How to Do It	17
Step 1: Choose your repertoire	17
Step 2: Research and write Section 1	17
Step 3: Creating exercise and Section 2 statement	18
Step 4: Performed adaptation and Section 3 statement	18
Step 5: Compile the submission	19
Connection Between Sections	19
 Exploring: Checklist	 21
Repertoire decisions	21
Section 1: Exploration of diverse musical material	21
Section 2: Creating exercise	22
Section 3: Performed adaptation	22
Upload 1: Written document	22
Upload 2: Audio evidence	22
Upload 3: Audio reference material	23
Common errors to rule out	23
 Exploring: What Each Level Means	 25
Criterion A: Selection of Evidence	25
Criterion B1: Conducting Musical Research	26
Criterion B2: Implications	27
Criterion C1: Understanding Creating Conventions	28
Criterion C2: Understanding Performing Practices	30
The Glossary	31
 Exploring: Common Mistakes	 33
1. Non-specific descriptions	33

Table of contents

2. Detail without purpose	34
3. Drawing conclusions from too little evidence	34
4. Misidentifying areas of inquiry	35
5. Arrangement versus adaptation	36
 Experimenting with Music	 37
 Experimenting: Checklist	 39
Repertoire	39
 Experimenting: What Each Level Means	 41
Component Structure	41
Criteria A & C: Rationale and Commentary	41
Criteria B & D: Practical Experiments	43
The Glossary	45
 Experimenting: Common Mistakes	 47
1. Presenting instead of experimenting	47
2. Three disconnected experiments instead of a progressive series	47
3. Commentary that lists without explaining	47
4. Performing experiments that are actually creating experiments	48
5. Surface-level “transformation”	48
6. AOI 4 as a default for electronic music	49
7. Personal context	49
8. MuseScore as a primary source	49
9. Performing someone else’s existing adaptation	49
 Presenting Music	 51
 Presenting: What Each Level Means	 53
Criterion A: Programme Notes	53
Criterion B: Musicality and Technical Proficiency of Created Works	54
Criterion C: Musicality and Technical Proficiency of Performed Works	56
Criterion D: Musical Communication	58
The Glossary	59
 Presenting: Common Mistakes	 61
1. AOIs that exist but are not linked	61
2. Treating “creating” as arrangement or transcription	62
3. Not being audible in ensembles	62
4. Submissions that are too short	63
5. Notation that doesn’t communicate	63
6. Criterion D treated as a repeat of B and C	64

The Contemporary Music Maker (HL)	65
CMM: What Each Level Means	67
Component Overview	67
Criterion A: Selection of Evidence	68
Criterion B: Discussion of the Process	69
Criterion C: Musicality and Technical Proficiency	71
Criterion D: Organisation and Presentation	72
CMM: Common Mistakes	75
1. The project plan treated as process evidence	75
2. All words, no musical evidence	75
3. Describing collaboration, not reflecting on musical decisions	76
4. Using higher-level language without higher-level thinking	76
5. A non-musical role	77
6. Multiple students sharing the same presentation	77
7. The final product is missing	77
8. Insufficient use of the time allowance	78
9. The arrangement problem	78

Preface

This book is the written companion to the DP Music course. It is organized by the four assessment components and is designed for independent study and review.

The four components:

- **Exploring Music in Context** — Research, analysis, and practical exercises demonstrating knowledge of musical conventions and performance practices
- **Experimenting with Music** — A series of documented experiments in creating and performing, developing musical ideas through informed decision-making
- **Presenting Music** — A portfolio of completed performing and creating works, presented with programme notes across four areas of inquiry
- **The Contemporary Music Maker** (HL only) — A collaborative real-life musical project, documented as a multimedia presentation

Assessment Guidance

Synthesised from: DP Music Additional Guidance (IB, 2024) and subject reports Nov 2022, May 2023, May 2024, Nov 2024, May 2025.

Requirements that apply to every component

Areas of inquiry must be justified, not just stated. Every piece must be connected to an AOI through analytical argument. Naming the AOI and then listing unrelated musical features does not constitute justification. The analysis must explain what, specifically, in the music supports that classification. A piece can fit multiple AOIs; the student must provide evidence for whichever they claim. One way to approach this is to think of the exploring report as a persuasive essay in which you state the AOI and then convince the reader through use of evidence.

In-text references are not optional. All sources — scores, recordings, journal articles, interviews — must be cited at the point where they are used. A bibliography at the end does not substitute for in-text references. Unsupported claims are unsubstantiated regardless of how well-written they are.

Timestamps and bar numbers must point to submitted evidence. Any audio reference must correspond to a file the examiner can access — Upload 2 or Upload 3 depending on the component. Timestamps from YouTube, Spotify, or original tracks are unverifiable and do not count as evidence. Similarly, score references need bar numbers, instrument designation, clef, and key marked clearly.

Use annotated excerpts, not decorative ones. Score excerpts, screenshots, and images must do visible analytical work. A front page of a score, an image of a composer, or an unannotated DAW screenshot does not constitute evidence. If the student is not pointing to something specific, the examiner cannot see the analytical claim.

Characteristics are not conventions. A feature found in one piece is not necessarily a convention of a style. Establishing a convention requires examining multiple representative examples of a style. A symphony written in A major does not mean all symphonies are in A major; the use of figured bass in Baroque music is a convention. The distinction must be made before building a creating exercise or adaptation on it.

Exploring Music in Context

Recommended approach

The component has a clear chain: research → written exploration → practical exercises. These are not independent tasks. The exploration in section 1 must be the foundation for the work in sections 2 and 3. Submissions that treat them as separate tasks cannot establish implications (Criterion B2) and cannot demonstrate informed conventions and performance practices (C1/C2).

The recommended sequence:

1. Analyse a wide range of music across two areas of inquiry and three contexts (personal, local, global)
2. Decide which pieces will serve as the stimulus for the creating exercise and performed adaptation
3. Identify and extract the specific creating and performing conventions from those pieces
4. Apply those conventions in the practical exercises
5. Explain how the research informed the practical work, including challenges and successes

Repertoire selection

- **Required:** music from personal, local, and global contexts; at least two areas of inquiry
- **Recommended:** 3–4 pieces; fewer risks too little diversity, more risks too little depth within the word limit. More pieces explored shallowly typically score lower than fewer pieces explored purposefully
- The creating exercise and performed adaptation must be based on pieces that appear and are genuinely explored in section 1

Score and audio reference materials

- All score excerpts must appear in the body of the written work, annotated and labelled with bar numbers, instrumentation, clef, and key visible. Appendix-only score references are not practical for examiners
- Audio evidence: use only timestamps from Upload 3 (the audio reference material), not from original recordings. Do not reference YouTube, Spotify, or original commercial tracks as locatable evidence
- Timestamps must be precise and point to the specific moment being analysed; a 40-second audio example that says “here you will find contrasting dynamics” makes the examiner do the analysis, not the student

Creating exercise (Criterion C1)

The creating exercise is best understood as a musical sketch that expresses the wider conventions of the source material’s style — not a sophisticated re-interpretation. The test is whether the student has demonstrated understanding of what makes the style distinctive, not whether the result

is polished. An exercise that composes “in a style” without identifying specific conventions that are accepted norms across multiple representative examples of that style will not score well.

- The exercise must be based on a piece already explored in section 1
- Arrangements, compositions, and improvisations are all acceptable creating processes
- Notation requirements: include score up to 32 bars and/or 1 minute of audio appropriate to the style; bar numbers, clef, and key signature must appear

Performed adaptation (Criterion C2)

The adaptation is a musical problem-solving exercise: identifying how performing practices specific to a style can be transferred to the student’s own instrument, using that instrument’s idiomatic capabilities. It is not a transcription of the notes.

- Playing the notes of a tango on a flute is a transcription. A performance adaptation of tango on flute requires identifying the specific bow/articulation techniques of tango violin — strong accents, staccatos, fast glissandos, playing behind the bridge — and finding equivalent extended techniques for flute: flutter tongue, key clicks, jet whistle, tongue stop. The adaptation should make the flute sound, as closely as possible, as if it were playing in the tango style *on violin*
- The adaptation is most likely to succeed when the source material uses a significantly different instrument or voice from the student’s own; this creates the productive challenge of genuine adaptation
- Performing to a backing track or simply changing the instrumentation without applying performance practices does not constitute adaptation. However, using a backing track is permitted
- The commentary must describe which specific performing practices from the original were identified and how they were transferred to the student’s instrument

Music technology in performing adaptation

- The submission must demonstrate active, real-time control of the technology — triggering sounds, manipulating parameters, controlling dynamics in performance
- The hands and physical engagement of the student must be audible in the recording
- Adaptations that blur the line between performance and composition are unlikely to do well
- The teacher authenticates the student’s live engagement in the Music–Coursework Authentication Form

Criterion-specific notes

Criterion A (Selection of Evidence)

- AOI designation affects the mark if incorrect. The most persistent error: pre-existing concert music (Bach, Beethoven, Mozart) used in a film is NOT film music. The AOI reflects the original compositional function, not subsequent use. Music composed for dramatic impact (ballet, opera, incidental music) can legitimately be AOI 3 — but only if the analysis focuses on the musical elements that support the dramatic function

- A Chopin waltz is not AOI 3 (entertainment/dance) simply because waltzes are danced — Chopin’s Opp. 18–64 are art music for listening (AOI 2), not functional dance music; the analysis must engage with that distinction
- Piazzolla’s tango works are not AOI 3 simply because “tango is dance music” — widely available scholarship demonstrates that Piazzolla’s pieces were not intended for dancing. The AOI placement must be grounded in research, not assumption about the genre
- Evidence must be informative and specific. A vague audio reference (“here you’ll find dynamics”) cannot be credited as evidence
- Analyses based solely on audio excerpts are limited in sophistication, especially if the audio provided does not correspond to the specific passage being discussed

Criterion B1 (Conducting Musical Research)

- Anecdotal biographical information (date of birth, childhood events, education) is rarely relevant and uses word count that could support analytical claims. Select only what determines the conventions or performance practices of the style
- Research limited to the first website found is not likely to be purposeful. The research must draw from primary sources (scores, recordings, interviews with performers/composers) and credible secondary sources (musicological texts, journal articles)
- Extra-musical findings must be relevant to the music, not general context. They contextualize the musical findings; they do not replace them
- Analysis must connect musical findings to the AOI: a candidate selecting electronic music must explain the specific technology-based elements that constitute its defining features, not just name a key or tempo

Criterion B2 (Implications)

- Implications require genuine exploration to exist. If the practical exercises draw on pieces not explored in section 1, the implication cannot be established. Several reports across all sessions identify this as a recurring problem: pieces listed in sections 2–3 with no corresponding analysis in section 1

Criterion C1 (Understanding Creating Conventions)

- The creating exercise is assessed against the style, not only the single stimulus piece. The student must demonstrate understanding of what is conventional across the style, not just features of the one chosen piece. Mozart’s *Ein musikalischer Spaß* (K 522) deliberately violates classical conventions through satire (parallel fifths, dissonances, wrong keys in sonata form); a student exploring only this piece would misidentify those satirical elements as conventions of the 1st Vienna School
- Compositions that freely “compose in a style” without grounding specific choices in identified conventions generally reach only the lower mark bands
- Conventions stem from the organization of musical material within a style; they cannot be assembled by mixing isolated features from disparate pieces. Attempts to merge unrelated conventions from several different styles tend to be unconvincing and produce stylistically incoherent results

Criterion C2 (Understanding Performing Practices)

- Adaptation, not arrangement: arranging a flamenco stimulus into jazz is not adaptation; it is producing a new piece in a different style. The adaptation must engage with the specific performing practices of the original style and transfer them to the student's instrument
 - Following the written notation closely is a sign that transcription is occurring, not adaptation. For baroque music, this means adding period ornamentation and appropriate articulation. For jazz, it means applying swing and stylistic inflection. For any tradition with a strong oral/aural dimension, it means learning from listening rather than reading
 - Multi-track recordings are not automatically an adaptation. Layering parts on top of one another demonstrates production, not stylistic adaptation. The adaptation must show how performing practices of the original style are reinterpreted idiomatically for the student's instrument
-

Experimenting with Music

Structure

Six experiments in total: three in creating, three in performing. Within each role:

- Performing experiments form a progressive series: each grows from the previous one
- Creating experiments form a separate progressive series: each grows from the previous one
- The two series must **not** be linked to each other; they evolve from different sources/stimuli

The goal is developing musical ideas through informed, experimental decision-making — personalising and transforming a stimulus rather than recreating it. The component is assessed as “doing something to see what happens, then analysing the outcome to inform the next intentional step.”

Students who include evaluative commentary *and* a connecting statement that explains their musical intentions for the next experiment consistently achieve higher marks.

Performing experiments

- Based on experimentation with performing techniques: bowing, articulation, flutter tongue, overblowing, pitch bending, phrasing, stylistic interpretation
- The focus should be techniques the student does not normally use — unfamiliar or innovative approaches to a stimulus
- The commentary must focus on performance aspects only, not on improvement or refinement of playing skill. A diary-like account of “what I practised” or “how my technique improved” does not address the criterion
- Performing experimentally does not require radical technique; it requires that experimenting decisions are applied, that the effect is audible in the recording, and that the student has evaluated what happened
- Reproducing an existing adaptation found online (e.g., a jazz arrangement of a pop song from YouTube) and performing it in the same way is reiterating, not experimenting. The experimentation must originate with the student

- Multi-tracking is not a substitute for performing. A student who multi-tracks themselves is producing layers of arrangement; the performing experiment is assessed on what is executed in performance, not on the arranging decisions that preceded it

Creating experiments

- Begin with a clearly identified stimulus; experiments that start from a style or artist without a specific piece are harder for examiners to evaluate for development of musical ideas
- Arranging, composing, and improvisation are all acceptable creating processes
- Candidates who compose in a style without connecting to an actual stimulus tend to achieve only the recreating mark band, because there is no source material against which the development of ideas can be evaluated
- Three disconnected creating samples score less well than a purposeful series where each experiment grows from analysis of the previous

Developing the commentary

For each experiment, the commentary should address:

- **What:** what source material is being used (cite and reference it)
- **Why:** why this source or approach was chosen (musical reasoning, not personal preference)
- **How:** how the source material informed the experiment and the musical decisions made
- **What next:** how the results/findings of this experiment inform the intentions for the next one (criteria A and C)

Use musical terminology and elements to describe the experimental process concretely. Screenshots of DAW screens must be explained; an unannotated image of a DAW communicates nothing on its own.

Areas of inquiry and contexts in Experimenting

- Students investigate music from local or global contexts; **personal context does not apply in this component**
- The justification of context is how the student explains why they selected their source material; it should be connected to musical reasons
- The AOI should be connected to the purpose or function of the music and should appear in the rationale and recur meaningfully in the commentary — not only be named at the start and then ignored
- AOI 4 is not a default category for music that uses electronic instruments. Pop and rock music that happens to use electric guitars or synthesizers is not automatically AOI 4; the classification must reflect the music's relationship to electronic or digital technology as the defining characteristic of how it is created, performed, or produced

Assessment submission requirements

- Include a brief audio clip (maximum 20 seconds) of the source material at the start of each experiment
- Scores for creating/performing as applicable should be included as an appendix
- Exact locations in scores and audio files must be given: measure numbers, beats, voice/instrument designations; exact timings in audio files
- Criteria B and D assess the treatment of source material (reiterate → recreate → adapt → transform); written and audio evidence must clearly support what is claimed
- MuseScore is not a reliable source of authentic scores. It is an online library of user-submitted transcriptions with no guarantee of authenticity. Students using MuseScore should verify the material against authoritative sources before treating it as a primary score reference

Technology in Experimenting

- Specify which AOI the technology serves within the experiment
- Explain how the technology was used to develop the practical work — decision-making, not just “I used a DAW”
- Use correct terminology for the software and hardware
- In performed experiments using technology: the use must demonstrate active, real-time manipulation — live electronic performance, DJing, computer-based performance, interactive installations. Performed experiments that blur the line between performance and pre-composed output are not likely to score well
- Students engaging in technology performance should detail in the commentary how they engaged with the technology in live performance; this is authenticated by the teacher

Presenting Music

Programme notes (Criterion A)

- The programme notes justify the choice of works by showing that the student has addressed the required diversity and breadth across all four areas of inquiry
- AOIs should be a central part of the notes, not an afterthought. Each work’s connection to its AOI must be explained, not just stated
- Avoid personal reminiscence (“I chose this piece because it reminds me of my grandmother”) and lengthy biographical background on composers. Concentrate on musical facts and the link to the area of inquiry
- The most effective programme notes are written in the third person, present or past tense, and rely on musical specificity
- All sources must be referenced in-text and compiled in a bibliography at the end of the programme notes
- Where scores accompany created works, they must be included; submissions without scores for created works cannot fully demonstrate what the student has done

Ensemble submissions

For the student's work to be assessed fairly, their individual contribution must be distinctly audible. Where this is not possible:

- Prefer smaller ensembles or works where the individual can be identified
- Recording the ensemble with a microphone positioned close to the student is strongly recommended
- Submit a balance of ensemble and solo works; this provides more comprehensive evidence
- Where no solo works exist, submit clearly chosen excerpts of the student's individual part from ensemble recordings; these must demonstrate the full range of the student's musical and technical capability, aligned in quality and demand with the ensemble submission

Music technology performance — video submission

Technology performances are submitted via video (Upload 3). The video must show the student's hands and physical engagement with the technology — not a screen recording from a DAW. Examples of what constitutes active technology performance:

- Real-time sound manipulation
- Dynamic control via physical controllers
- Triggering sounds rhythmically using launchpads or foot pedals
- Synchronising physical movement to loops or sequences in real time (loop pedals, Ableton-style triggering)

Submissions where the student primarily monitors pre-composed playback are not demonstrating performance skills.

Presenting as creator

- Technology-based improvisations and compositions must be submitted as audio (Upload 2); video cannot be evaluated for creating
- Visual evidence supporting the creating role — DAW screenshots, annotated score extracts — belongs in the programme notes (Upload 1)
- Notation is required for all created works:
 - Staff/stave screenshots from a DAW alone are limited; annotate and explain them
 - Graphic notation showing filter changes and parameter shifts is useful for electronic works
 - MIDI piano roll view (not notation view) is preferred for showing note data; GarageBand's notation view is often inaccurate
 - Do not submit audio waveform screenshots — these represent sound, not musical notes

Criterion D (Musical Communication)

- Musical intentions described in the programme notes must be recognisable in the recordings; features discussed in the notes should be audible in the audio
- Recording quality matters significantly. Recordings from laptops and phones are often insufficient. Schools should ensure students have access to appropriate recording equipment
- Performances submitted for “presenting as performer” may not be mastered or otherwise edited
- Backing tracks are discouraged; they prevent demonstrating a full range of musical skills. Where necessary, the backing track should be played through good speakers, carefully balanced, and the student should remain clearly audible
- Intonation is part of technical proficiency and should be treated with the same priority as all other musical elements

Instrument declaration

If a student performs on more than one instrument or combines singing with playing, this must be declared in the 6/MPM form and reflected in the programme notes. It is rarely the case that a student has equal technical facility on multiple instruments; including an additional instrument or voice at which the student is weaker may reduce rather than enhance the overall mark.

The Contemporary Music Maker (HL only)

Overview

CMM requires students to engage in collaborative, real-life musical projects as researchers, creators, and performers. The emphasis is on artistic control and musical leadership within a project the student designs. This component puts the greatest premium on the depth of musical process, decision-making, and collaboration — not polish or finished product alone.

Roles

- Students identify one primary practical musical role (creator or performer); research is an inherent part of all roles
- The identified primary role is the one assessed in Criterion C (technical and musical proficiency)
- It is not necessary to engage all three roles, but the student must clearly identify and lead in their primary practical role
- Other roles (managerial, directorial) are natural in collaborative projects but should not overshadow musical development in the documentation

Musical intention

Musical intentions include: the role of the student leader, the nature and scope of collaboration, and the intended outcome and audience. Students establish specific musical goals informed by their artistic intentions, their research, and the needs of the project.

Collaborators

- Collaborators must be of school age — secondary school students or younger, from the same or different schools
- It is not acceptable to collaborate with graduates, college students, professionals, or teachers
- Collaboration requires genuine interpersonal musical exchange that can be documented. Responding to a stimulus independently (e.g., writing music inspired by a painting without interaction) does not constitute collaboration for the purposes of Criterion B

Process documentation (Criterion B)

Criterion B is consistently the most challenging across all assessment sessions. Full marks require evidence of all of the following in relation to the student's stated aims:

- Discussion of challenges and successes
- Examination of areas for development and strategies for improvement
- Evaluation of musical and collaborative choices made

The process documentation (Upload 1, Part 1) should:

- Reference the stages of development clearly and in order
- Include reflective and evaluative commentary throughout (not just planning)
- Provide precise references to scores, workstation visuals, and audio timestamps
- Avoid spending the majority of time on planning; the planning section should synthesize the project's key concepts briefly, leaving the majority of space for the development process

Many students spend significant space on planning and insufficient space on process. The criterion B descriptors are about the process, not the plan.

A recurring problem is the use of criterion B language without the corresponding depth. Writing "I evaluated my choices" or "I examined areas for development" while providing only surface-level reflection does not satisfy the descriptors for those terms. The depth of engagement must match what the command term requires — *evaluate* means weighing strengths and limitations; *examine* means uncovering assumptions and interrelationships.

Multimedia presentation

The multimedia presentation should be treated as a designed artifact — a purposefully constructed piece of communication — rather than a spoken explanation accompanied by static slides.

- Include continuous narration in the form of voice-over or subtitles
- Speak slowly and clearly — this aids understanding of the student's reasoning

- Align visuals carefully with the narrated/subtitled commentary
- Include visuals and text on screen to support the commentary; over-reliance on speaking over static slides is discouraged
- Dynamic elements — rehearsal footage, interviews, behind-the-scenes content — engage the assessor and provide better evidence of the collaborative process
- Do not include hyperlinks. Examiners cannot click links within the submission; any material that exists only via a URL cannot be assessed
- In collaborative projects, each student must submit their own individual presentation. Multiple students sharing the same multimedia presentation makes it impossible to distinguish individual contributions and will prevent individual assessment

Upload structure

Upload 1 (max 15 minutes):

- Organized as: process evidence first, final product second
- Part 1 (process): document how the project developed; focus on criterion B evidence; can be organized chronologically or around each criterion B descriptor
- Part 2 (final product): may be curated; must not exceed 7 minutes of the 15-minute total; the student is assessed only on material presented in the video; criterion C mark is based on the final product evidence alone

Upload 2:

- The detailed project plan is the primary document; introduce it with a brief synthesis paragraph
- Include full scores of any compositions referenced in the multimedia presentation
- All primary and secondary sources must be included; if the student has arranged material, the original material must also be uploaded so the examiner can assess the student's work against it

Identifying the student

The student must be clearly identifiable within the video submission. Face blurring is not required. A brief visual or verbal self-introduction is effective. In collaborative projects, it must be unambiguous which work and which contributions belong to the assessed student.

Assessment submission checklist (all components)

	Exploring	Experimenting	Presenting	CMM
AOIs justified				—
Contexts justified			—	—

Assessment Guidance

	Exploring	Experimenting	Presenting	CMM
In-text references				
Annotated score excerpts				
Audio timestamps			—	
Performance practices applied				—
Technology = real-time active performance				—
Student individually identifiable	—	—		
Personal context NOT applicable	—		—	—

*Note regarding personal context: You must **not** engage with familiar pieces for Experimenting; for Presenting and the CMM, you may, but there is no need to justify it. In Exploring, you **must** include at least one (and probably only one) piece from personal context.*

Exploring Music in Context

Exploring: How to Do It

The Exploring component asks you to do three things: **research** diverse music, **create** a short piece in a style you explored, and **adapt** music from an unfamiliar context for your own instrument. These three parts are connected — your research must directly inform both exercises.

What you submit:

- Upload 1: one written document (max 2,400 words)
 - Upload 2: one audio file containing your practical work (max 4 min)
 - Upload 3: one audio file of the music you analysed (max 3 min)
-

Step 1: Choose your repertoire

Choose **3–4 pieces** early. They must collectively cover:

- **At least two areas of inquiry** (AOI 1, 2, 3, or 4)
- **All three contexts:** one personal, at least one local, at least one global

At the same time, decide which piece will anchor each exercise:

Exercise	Source	AOI requirement	Context requirement
Creating exercise	Any piece from your Section 1 research	—	—
Performed adaptation	Music from a local or global context	Different AOI from the creating exercise	Local or global only — NOT personal

Step 2: Research and write Section 1

Section 1 is your exploration of the music — roughly 1800 words of the 2,400 total.

For each piece, produce two types of findings:

Musical findings — from the music itself (score, recording):

- What musical elements and devices define this piece?

- What makes this style distinctive — what conventions does it use?
- How are these things used to create meaning or effect?

Extra-musical findings — from sources about the music (articles, interviews, documentaries):

- When and where was this music made? What was its context?
- What was the composer's or performer's intention?
- How does the context explain the musical choices?

Write analytically, not descriptively. Don't narrate what you hear. Explain *why* the music works the way it does. Connect every finding to the style, the AOI, and/or the creative intention.

Every musical observation needs a **bar number and/or timestamp** pointing to Upload 3. Every claim drawn from a source needs an **in-text citation**.

Step 3: Creating exercise and Section 2 statement

Compose a short piece (max 32 bars, or 1 min audio) in the style of one of your explored pieces. This is a **sketch**, not a polished work. The goal is to demonstrate that you understand the style's conventions.

Write a brief statement (~300 words) that explains:

- Which specific creating conventions you applied and where in the exercise
- How your Section 1 research directly informed your choices
- Any challenges you encountered

Include the score or notation **embedded in the document**. If the style doesn't use staff notation, use an appropriate form (tablature, graphic notation, DAW screenshot). Include an audio track (max 1 min) in Upload 2.

Step 4: Performed adaptation and Section 3 statement

Record yourself adapting music from a **local or global** context for your own instrument. The stimulus (the original music you worked from) goes into Upload 2 (max 1 min). Your performed adaptation follows (max 2 min).

The exercise is not a transcription. You are identifying the **performing practices** of the original style and finding ways to realize them on your instrument — which may require extended techniques or creative solutions.

Write a brief statement (~300 words) that explains:

- Which performing conventions or practices you identified in the original style

- How you adapted them for your instrument, including where it worked and where it didn't
 - Any challenges and how you resolved them
-

Step 5: Compile the submission

Upload 1 — Written document (max 2,400 words):

Compile in this order:

1. Section 1: Exploration of diverse musical material
2. Section 2: Statement on the creating exercise (with score embedded)
3. Section 3: Statement on the performed adaptation
4. Bibliography (*not counted in the word limit*)

Visual evidence (score excerpts, annotated screenshots, diagrams) must be embedded in the text — not appended. Maximum 5 pages of visual material in total.

Upload 2 — Practical work (max 4 min total):

Compile in this order:

1. Creating exercise audio (*max 1 min*)
2. Stimulus for the performed adaptation (*max 1 min*)
3. Performed adaptation (*max 2 min*)

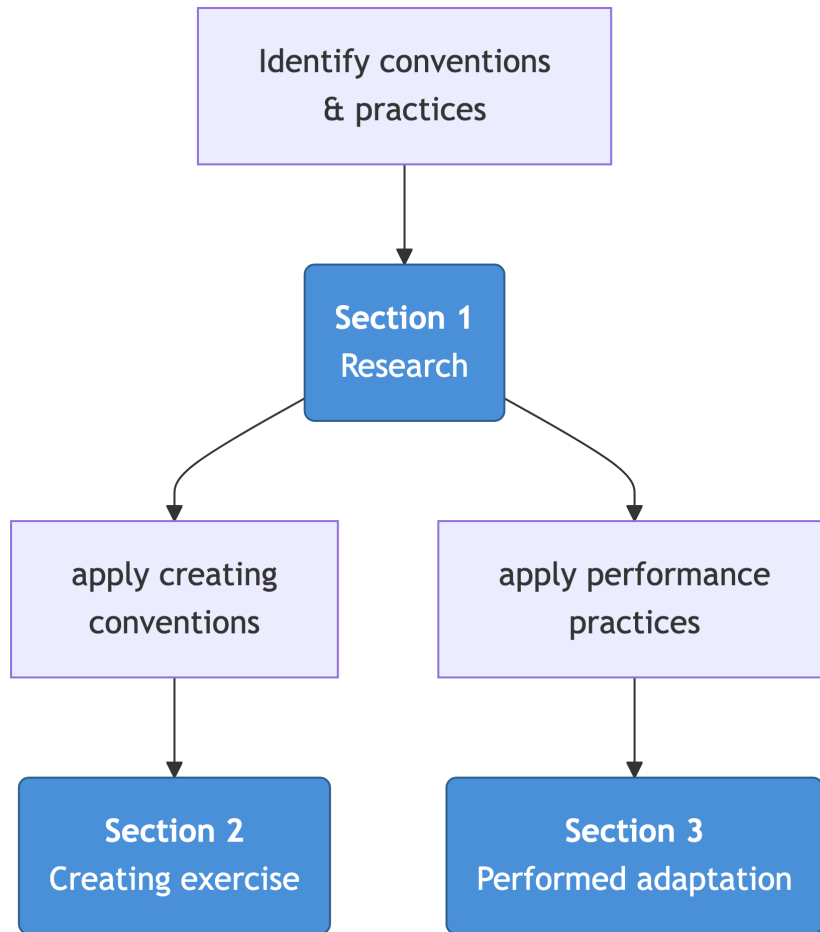
Upload 3 — Reference material (max 3 min total):

Excerpts of the music you analyzed in Section 1, in the order they appear in your writing.

Connection Between Sections

Every part of the submission should connect logically:

Section 1 research → identifies conventions and practices → Section 2 creating exercise applies the creating conventions; Section 3 performed adaptation applies the performance practices



If the practical exercises do not grow from the research, Criterion B2 (Implications) cannot be awarded. If the research is superficial, there is nothing meaningful to apply.

Exploring: Checklist

Repertoire decisions

Add 4th Piece

- ☐ At least **two different areas of inquiry** are represented across all pieces
 - ☐ All **three contexts** are covered: personal, local, and global
 - ☐ Creating exercise stimulus is identified (a piece explored in Section 1)
 - ☐ Performed adaptation stimulus is identified: **local or global context**, different AOI from creating
-

Section 1: Exploration of diverse musical material

For each piece:

- ☐ Area of inquiry is **stated and justified** — not just named
 - ☐ Context (personal/local/global) is justified
 - ☐ **Musical findings** are present (from scores/recordings): conventions, devices, techniques
 - ☐ Musical findings are located with **bar numbers or exact timestamps** pointing to Upload 3
 - ☐ **Extra-musical findings** are present (from articles, interviews, etc.)
 - ☐ Extra-musical findings are **relevant** to the music — not anecdotal biography
 - ☐ All sources have **in-text citations** — not only a bibliography at the end
 - ☐ Analysis explains *why* devices are used
-

Section 2: Creating exercise

- ☐ Based on a style **explored in Section 1**
 - ☐ Creating exercise audio included in Upload 2 (*max 1 min*)
 - ☐ Score or notation **embedded in the document** (max 32 bars or 1 min audio)
 - ☐ Notation is appropriate to the style and clearly communicates the exercise
 - ☐ Statement explains which **creating conventions** were applied and **where**
 - ☐ Statement explains how **Section 1 research directly informed** the exercise
-

Section 3: Performed adaptation

- ☐ Stimulus (original music) included in Upload 2 (*max 1 min*)
 - ☐ Performed adaptation audio included in Upload 2 (*max 2 min*)
 - ☐ From a **local or global** context — NOT personal
 - ☐ Statement explains which **performing practices** were identified in the original style
 - ☐ Statement explains how practices were **adapted for your instrument**
 - ☐ Adaptation AOI is confirmed as **different from creating** AOI
-

Upload 1: Written document

- ☐ Word count is within **2,400 words** (in-text citations and bibliography excluded)
 - ☐ Compiled in one pdf in order: **Section 1 → Section 2 → Section 3 → Bibliography**
 - ☐ Visual evidence is **embedded in the text**, not appended
 - ☐ Visual evidence does not exceed **5 pages**
 - ☐ Score for creating exercise is embedded in Section 2
 - ☐ Track list and timings included as appendix (not in word count)
 - ☐ Bibliography complete and includes all scores, recordings, and secondary sources
-

Upload 2: Audio evidence

- ☐ Total audio does not exceed **4 minutes**
- ☐ Compiled in order: **Creating exercise → Stimulus → Performed adaptation**
- ☐ Creating exercise audio does not exceed **1 minute**
- ☐ Stimulus does not exceed **1 minute**
- ☐ Performed adaptation does not exceed **2 minutes**
- ☐ Audio quality allows full assessment of the exercises

- ☐ Exact timings are specified in the written document
-

Upload 3: Audio reference material

- ☐ Total audio does not exceed **3 minutes**
 - ☐ Contains only excerpts of **music analysed in Section 1**
 - ☐ Compiled in the order excerpts appear in the writing
 - ☐ Timestamps in Upload 3 match the references in the written document
-

Common errors to rule out

- ☐ Timestamps in writing point to **Upload 3** — not to YouTube, Spotify, or original commercial recordings
- ☐ Score excerpts are **annotated** and connected to specific analytical claims — not decorative
- ☐ AOIs are **justified with musical evidence** — not just labelled
- ☐ Creating exercise and performed adaptation are from **two different AOIs**
- ☐ Performed adaptation is based on **local or global** music — not personal
- ☐ Creating exercise and adaptation are both referenced **back to Section 1 research**
- ☐ Word count checked with citations removed

Exploring: What Each Level Means

The Exploring rubrics list *possible characteristics* (Ineffective, Suitable, Purposeful, etc.) alongside the mark bands, but the subject guide does not define them. This page explains what each band looks like in practice, criterion by criterion.

Criterion A: Selection of Evidence

This criterion focuses on the diversity, breadth, and balance of the material you select as evidence.

What “diversity and breadth” requires: contrasting materials from personal, local, and global contexts across at least two areas of inquiry.

What “balance” requires: roughly equal treatment of the areas of inquiry and contexts across the portfolio — not three pieces from one area and one token piece from another.

The three levels

Band	What it looks like
Ineffective / Rudimentary	Evidence doesn’t meaningfully support your claims. Generic, unverifiable, or out of context. No in-text references to specific sources, scores, or recordings. The examiner cannot trace your statements back to anything.
Suitable / Inconsistently balanced	Evidence is present and relevant but uneven — some strong, some weak. Some areas of inquiry are treated more thoroughly than others. References may be present in some sections but missing elsewhere.
Relevant / Purposefully balanced	Evidence is well-chosen and directly supports your musical and extra-musical claims. In-text references allow the examiner to verify every claim. Areas of inquiry and contexts are treated with equity across the portfolio. Both notated and audio examples are used where appropriate, with timestamps that correctly match the cited track.

What this looks like in practice

Stating areas of inquiry without justification — saying “this piece belongs to Area of Inquiry 3” is not enough. You need to *explain and justify* why. What about the music’s function, context, or purpose places it there?

Effective use of evidence — presenting both a score excerpt and the corresponding audio, with timestamps that correctly match the recording, makes your evidence verifiable. An examiner can check it. That is effective evidence.

In-text references — every claim that depends on a source (a recording, a score, a journal article, an interview) needs an in-text reference. A bibliography at the end does not substitute for in-text citations. Without them, the evidence is unsubstantiated regardless of how well-written the argument is.

Score without annotation — including a score excerpt with no markings or commentary leaves the examiner unable to see how it supports your argument. Evidence must do visible work.

Incorrect area of inquiry designation — assigning a piece to the wrong area of inquiry affects your mark through the first bullet point. The most common error is presenting pre-existing concert music as “film music” simply because it appeared in a film. The area of inquiry reflects the *original function and intention* of the music, not its later use.

Criterion B1: Conducting Musical Research

This criterion assesses the quality of your musical analysis — how well you locate, communicate, and apply musical and extra-musical findings.

The criterion has three distinct parts assessed separately:

1. **The findings themselves** — are they listed, described, or explained?
2. **The effectiveness of the findings** — are they superficial, reasonable, or purposeful?
3. **Terminology** — is it inaccurate, inconsistent, or accurate?
4. **Localisation** — are musical findings placed inaccurately, inconsistently, or accurately in the score/recording?

The three levels

Band	What it looks like
Ineffective / Superficial	Analysis narrates events rather than explaining them. Lists facts about the music that could apply to almost any piece (tempo, time signature, dynamic markings). Terminology is absent or misused. No bar numbers or timestamps.

Band	What it looks like
Inconsistent / Reasonable	Some analysis goes beyond description, but inconsistently. Some findings are purposeful; others remain at the surface. Terminology is present but not always applied correctly. Localisation is sometimes precise, sometimes vague.
Accurate / Purposeful	Analysis explains <i>why</i> musical devices are used, not just <i>what</i> they are. Findings are connected to the area of inquiry — the analysis serves a purpose beyond cataloguing. Terminology is accurate and used fluently. Bar numbers and timestamps are consistently provided.

What this looks like in practice

Purposeful analysis — a student analysing a Mozart duet who identifies structural phrase patterns *and* connects them to how the music depicts the character’s personality is doing purposeful analysis. The musical device is linked to its function within the area of inquiry. This is explaining, not describing.

Indicating obvious things — colour-coding notes in a score to show their register, or naming which instruments play which part, may look like analysis but is not. The examiner can see this without the student’s help. Describing what is already obvious on the page does not constitute musical research.

Vague and generalised — writing “the music is expressive and uses many dynamics” without referencing specific moments, measures, or effects is vague. There is no localisation, no precise terminology, no analytical claim.

The “so what” test — for every finding, ask: *so what?* If the answer is “nothing in particular, it’s just a fact about the piece,” the finding is probably not purposeful. If the answer is “this is what makes this style distinctive, and it’s why I can apply it in my creation,” it is purposeful.

Extra-musical findings — these come from sources *about* the music (journal articles, documentaries, interviews) rather than from the music itself. They are purposeful when they contextualise your musical findings — explaining historical context, cultural significance, or the composer’s intention. They are not purposeful when they are general background information that has no bearing on your analysis.

Criterion B2: Implications

This criterion assesses how clearly you connect your research (section 1) to your practical work (creating and adaptation).

The three levels

Band	What it looks like
Outlines	A basic connection is stated but not developed. The student identifies what was found but does not explain how it shaped the creative or adaptive decisions.
Describes	The connection between exploration and practice is explained at a general level. The student describes how the research influenced their decisions but does not demonstrate deliberate, specific application.
Explains	The link is analytical and specific. The student identifies particular stylistic or performance conventions found during exploration, then demonstrates — with reference to the actual work — how each was embedded into the creating or adaptation exercise.

What this looks like in practice

Strong implications — after exploring Gamelan music, a student addresses the specific challenge of adapting idiomatic Gamelan techniques to piano. They identify what they found, explain the idiomatic limitation, and describe the specific solution adopted. The reader can see the chain: *research finding* → *challenge* → *decision*.

Explicit reconnection — placing the stimulus material and the student's creation side-by-side, pointing directly to which element from the exploration appears where in the creation, is a strong technique. The link is demonstrated, not just asserted.

Weak implications — basing the creating or adaptation exercise on a style that was not explored in section one. Without genuine research underpinning the practical work, implications cannot be established.

Note on double-penalising — if your exploration contains inaccurate findings (e.g., identifying a feature that is not actually a convention of the style), you will not be penalised twice — once in B1 and again in B2. If you sincerely derived implications from your research, even if the research was imperfect, those implications can still be credited in B2.

Criterion C1: Understanding Creating Conventions

This criterion assesses the creating exercise — specifically whether it demonstrates genuine understanding of the stylistic and technical conventions of the chosen style.

The three levels

Band	What it looks like
Approximates	The creation imitates the surface features of a style without demonstrating understanding of what is essential to it. Generic or incorrect elements are presented as conventions.
Exhibits	The creation applies recognisable conventions of the style. The student demonstrates familiarity with the style, but the application may be formulaic — technically correct but without personal musical choices.
Realizes	The creation demonstrates confident, stylistically convincing application of conventions. The student shows genuine understanding of what makes the style distinctive, and the conventions are applied with intention and control.

What this looks like in practice

Harmonic conventions in pop — correctly identifying that a style uses specific harmonic progressions as a *characteristic* feature, and incorporating similar progressions purposefully into the creation, demonstrates understanding of convention. Mentioning that the piece uses chords without explaining why they are stylistically significant does not.

Strong realisation (Bach chorales) — a student who identifies the use of imperfect cadences in a Bach chorale, annotates the stimulus accordingly, and then incorporates this technique into their composition demonstrates stylistic understanding. Minor notation errors elsewhere do not negate evidence of understanding in C1.

Vague conventions (jazz) — stating “I am composing in a jazz style” without identifying specific jazz conventions (extended harmony, swing rhythm, modal language, call-and-response) leaves the claim unsubstantiated. The piece may incidentally *sound* jazz-like, but without explicit identification and application of conventions, the evidence of understanding is not there.

Style versus stimulus — the creating exercise is assessed against the *style*, not just the single stimulus piece. If your stimulus is a piece that uses an instrument or technique unusual for its style, using that instrument or technique as the basis of your creation does not demonstrate understanding of the style as a whole. The creating conventions must be representative of the broader style, not just features of the one piece you happened to select.

Arrangements — the music guide permits the creating exercise to take the form of an arrangement. If you arrange existing material in a different style (your *explored* style), the question becomes whether the arrangement demonstrates understanding of the creating conventions of that style — polyrhythms, characteristic bass lines, harmonic language, and so on. The arrangement stands or falls on how convincingly it deploys those conventions, not on how ambitious or polished it sounds.

Hybrid conventions — conventions cannot be built by assembling isolated features from several different styles. They stem from how musical material is organised within a single style. An exercise that combines an element from jazz, an element from Baroque counterpoint, and an element from minimalism, without a coherent stylistic logic, is not demonstrating knowledge of any convention — it is demonstrating eclecticism. The creating exercise must be rooted in a specific, researched style.

Criterion C2: Understanding Performing Practices

This criterion assesses the performed adaptation — specifically whether it demonstrates understanding and application of the *performing practices* of the chosen style, adapted to your own instrument.

The three levels

Band	What it looks like
Approximates	The student plays through the material without applying performing practices. The result is a transcription or playthrough — technically derived from the style but without its idiomatic techniques.
Transmits	The student applies the performing practices of the style in a recognisable, accurate way. The rendition is technically correct but may lack expressive depth or personal adaptation.
Shapes	The student modifies and develops the performing practices, adapting them idiomatically to their own instrument. The performance demonstrates control, expressive intent, and genuine understanding of what the style demands.

What this looks like in practice

Transcription versus adaptation — playing the written notes of a tango on a different instrument is a transcription. The performance practices that make a tango sound like a tango — the specific articulations, rhythmic inflections, extended bow techniques, expressive slides — are not on the page. These must be understood, applied, and adapted. Playing the notes without these techniques is playing *the skeleton* of a tango, not the tango.

Adaptation to your instrument — if you are adapting music that uses techniques specific to another instrument, you need to find equivalent techniques on your own. A flautist adapting violin tango techniques must identify what the technique *does expressively* and find an analogous technique for flute. This requires genuine understanding, not transcription.

Notation and adaptation — following the written notation closely does not constitute adaptation. If anything, the expectation is that you depart from the literal notation and apply the performance practices that experienced performers of the style use. For Baroque music, this means ornamentation, articulation, and phrasing conventions not marked in the score. For jazz, it means swing feel, improvisation conventions, and expressive inflection.

Understanding is rewarded, polish is not — if your technique is limited, but your written commentary and your performance both demonstrate that you understood the performing practices and made genuine decisions about how to apply them to your instrument, that understanding is credited. A technically imperfect performance that shows understanding can score higher than a polished performance that is simply a playthrough.

Multi-track recordings — recording multiple layers of yourself and combining them is a production technique, not a performed adaptation. Layering parts demonstrates arranging; it does not

demonstrate stylistic reinterpretation of performing practices. If you multi-track, each layer must itself apply the performing practices of the style idiomatically to your instrument.

The Glossary

These definitions are IB-published and shape how examiners read your work.

Term	IB definition
Balanced	A systematic and well-rounded study and/or representation of the chosen music.
Conventions	Accepted norms of creating music according to the chosen style, which are determined by historical research and authentic examples.
Musical findings	Information found by looking at the music itself — scores, performances, recordings.
Extra-musical findings	Information about the music found from sources outside the music — journal articles, interviews, documentaries — used to contextualise musical findings.
Performed adaptation	The candidate adjusts or modifies music with consideration of the original style and the instrument the music is being adapted for. Conventions of the original performance practice are explored and applied to their own instrument.
Primary sources	The music itself and people directly involved in its creation or performance: scores, live performances, recordings, composer interviews.
Secondary sources	Materials about the music by researchers not directly connected to it: critiques, documentaries, journal articles, editions.
Stylistic demands	The technical and idiomatic requirements to engage with a music-making process in a certain style.
Creating exercise	A short creation of 16–32 bars or 1 minute, notated appropriately for the chosen style. It applies and demonstrates knowledge of the conventions of the chosen context.

Exploring: Common Mistakes

These are the problems that appear most consistently across Exploring submissions. Understanding them in concrete terms is more useful than reading the rubric descriptors alone.

1. Non-specific descriptions

The problem: Analysis that could apply to almost any piece in any style.

Imagine being asked to describe two animals. You write: *“It has four legs. It has a tail. It makes sounds. It moves quickly.”* Nothing here identifies which animal you mean. Now add one piece of information: *“It uses echolocation.”* Immediately the field narrows to a handful of species. One more: *“It roosts in caves.”* Now you are describing a bat specifically.

The same logic applies to musical analysis. If someone reads your findings and cannot identify which style — or ideally which specific work — you are describing, your findings are not specific enough.

Statements like “this piece is in four-four,” “the tempo is allegro,” or “the dynamic is forte” are equivalent to “it has four legs.” They are true, they may be accurate, but they are not particular to anything. A student writing that a symphony is in four-four has not understood what is characteristic of a symphony. A student writing that mariachi music is “happy” has described a surface impression, not a convention.

What to ask instead: What does this piece do that a piece in a different style would not? What is essential to this style — the feature that defines it rather than merely characterises it?

Why it matters for marking: Findings that are non-specific cannot support a creating exercise or adaptation. If your analysis identifies only generic musical elements, your B2 implications will be weak, and your C1 and C2 exercises will lack a genuine foundation. The strength of the whole portfolio rests on the quality of what you found in section one.

2. Detail without purpose

The problem: Volume of detail presented as a substitute for insight.

Two anonymous piano pieces are shown to a group of musicians. They are asked to identify each one. One generates confident, convergent guesses (Stravinsky's *Rite of Spring*). The other generates no consensus (*Für Elise* by Beethoven).

Why the difference? The description of the first piece included: *frequent and irregular metre changes, unusual scales, dissonant harmony associated with the early twentieth century, a famous scandalous premiere*. Every piece of information narrowed the field further until only one piece fit. The description of the second included: *tonal harmony, piano solo, triple metre*. Each fact is true, and each is shared by thousands of pieces.

This illustrates the difference between *purposeful* and *descriptive* findings. A student who writes “the first three notes are G, E-flat, and E-flat, forte, with a rest” has given a lot of detail. None of it is useful, because none of it is particular to Beethoven's Fifth Symphony. A student who writes “the opening motivic cell — three short notes and a long — is used as the basis for almost every melodic and rhythmic idea throughout the symphony” has given one finding. It is highly purposeful.

The “so what” test: For every musical observation, ask yourself: *so what?* If the answer is “nothing in particular — it's just a fact,” the observation is probably not worth including. If the answer is “this is one of the features that defines this style, and without it the music would not be what it is,” you have a purposeful finding.

Extra-musical findings: The same test applies. “Mozart was born in Salzburg in 1756” is unlikely to pass the “so what” test. “The social function of Mozart's da Ponte operas required the music to characterise individual personalities through contrasting vocal textures” is extra-musical information that connects directly to the musical findings you might make about those operas.

3. Drawing conclusions from too little evidence

The problem: A single example used to establish a convention.

A researcher sent from another planet to determine what a dog looks like finds one photograph — of a three-legged dog. They conclude: dogs have three legs. The conclusion follows logically from the evidence available, and yet it is wrong, because one example cannot establish a convention.

The equivalent in music: a student listens to *Norwegian Wood* by The Beatles, hears a sitar, and concludes that the sitar is a convention of British rock music. The student then builds their creating exercise around the sitar as the defining element of the style. The convention has been drawn from one piece, and it is not representative.

Conventions are “accepted norms determined by historical research and authentic examples” (IB glossary). One piece is not enough.

The distinction between a convention and a feature: A feature is something one piece does. A convention is something a style consistently does. Electric bass guitar, driving eighth-note

patterns, a backbeat on beats two and four, distorted guitar in choruses — these are conventions of rock. A sitar in one song by one band is a feature, not a convention. It can still appear in your creating exercise, but it cannot be its defining element, because you cannot claim it represents the style.

How to check your conventions: Ask whether your secondary sources — books, articles, musical analyses of the style — support the conventions you have identified. If they do not appear in any general account of the style, they are probably features of your specific stimulus rather than conventions of the broader tradition.

Framing the stimulus correctly: If you choose a piece that is genuinely atypical — a Beatles song that experiments with Indian instrumentation as part of a documented aesthetic direction — you can narrow your area of inquiry accordingly. Writing about “The Beatles’ late-period experiments with Indian classical music” is a legitimate framing. Writing about “British rock conventions” and then presenting only the sitar is not.

4. Misidentifying areas of inquiry

The problem: Assigning a piece to an area of inquiry based on how it is used, rather than what it is.

A student selects a Mozart Requiem movement as an example of Area of Inquiry 3 (music for dramatic impact, movement and entertainment) because it appears in a film. The reasoning is: this music creates dramatic impact in the context of the film, therefore it belongs to Area of Inquiry 3.

The problem is that the area of inquiry reflects the *original function and intention* of the music, not its later use. Mozart was composing a liturgical work. The Requiem belongs to Area of Inquiry 1 (music for sociocultural and political expression, including religious traditions) or could be argued into Area of Inquiry 3 on its own musical terms (dramatic intent in the text setting, for example) — but not because a filmmaker later chose it. The dramatic impact the film derives from the music is the filmmaker’s achievement. Mozart was not composing for that film.

This error is common with any classical or art music that has been licensed for commercial use. The use does not determine the area of inquiry. If you want to argue for a particular area of inquiry on this basis, the argument must be grounded in the *music itself* — in the composer’s intention, the work’s original context, or the musical means by which the effect is achieved.

A related error: placing Piazzolla’s tango works in AOI 3 on the grounds that “tango is dance music.” Widely available scholarship shows that Piazzolla’s *nuevo tango* was explicitly composed for concert listening, not dancing — and Piazzolla himself insisted on this distinction. Placing a piece in an AOI on the basis of a general assumption about its genre, without checking what research says about the specific work, is the same error as the film music case. The AOI placement must be grounded in the music and its documented context.

5. Arrangement versus adaptation

The problem: Treating the performed adaptation as a transcription or arrangement rather than an exploration of performing practices.

The distinction between these three things is essential for C2:

- **Transcription:** The notes of the original transferred to a different instrument, played as written.
- **Arrangement:** The material reworked for a different medium — the notes changed, but still essentially the original piece in a new setting.
- **Adaptation:** The *performing practices* of the original style applied to your own instrument, with modifications that account for your instrument's idiomatic possibilities and limitations.

What performing practices are: They are the techniques, articulations, and expressive devices that experienced performers of a style use, most of which are *not written in the score*. A tango violinist does not just play the written notes. They apply specific bow techniques, rhythmic inflections, expressive slides, and articulation patterns that are learned by immersion in the tradition. These are the performing practices.

Playing the notes of a tango on a flute is a transcription. Playing the notes and adding a few articulations is a transcription with ornamentation. An adaptation would identify *what the tango bow techniques do expressively*, then find equivalent techniques on the flute — breath accents, flutter-tongue, extended articulation — that produce an analogous effect. The adaptation demonstrates that you understand *why* the techniques exist, not just *what* they are.

Adapting to your instrument's idiomatic possibilities: Extended techniques — sounds and effects that go beyond the instrument's conventional use — are often the mechanism by which performers adapt practices from other traditions. A pianist adapting tango techniques might explore the piano strings directly, use prepared piano, or use the pedals to approximate the sustained resonance of a bandoneón. These are not arbitrary novelties; they are solutions to the problem of realising an idiomatic practice on an instrument that was not designed for it.

Understanding is what is assessed, not polish: The quality of the performance in terms of technique or production is not what this criterion rewards. A poorly played but genuinely adaptive performance — one where the student has clearly understood the performing practices and made specific decisions about how to adapt them — can score more highly than a polished transcription. Evidence of understanding in the written commentary is credited alongside what is heard in the audio.

Following the notation too closely: If your adaptation stays very close to the written score, it is likely that you are transcribing rather than adapting. The performing practices of most styles require departure from the notation. For baroque music, this means ornamentation and phrasing conventions; for jazz, swing feel and stylistic inflection; for any style with a strong oral/aural tradition, it means applying what you have learned from listening to authentic performances, not just reading the page.

Experimenting with Music

Experimenting: Checklist

Repertoire

- ☐ At least **two different areas of inquiry** are represented across all pieces
- ☐ All **four areas of inquiry** are covered between Exploring and Experimenting

Experimenting: What Each Level Means

Component Structure

Experimenting has four criteria organised in two parallel pairs:

Pair	Criterion	Focus	Max marks
Creating	A	Rationale and commentary	6
Creating	B	Practical experiments	8
Performing	C	Rationale and commentary	6
Performing	D	Practical experiments	8

Criteria A and C have the same structure. Criteria B and D have the same structure. The creating series and the performing series evolve from different sources and must not be linked to each other.

Criteria A & C: Rationale and Commentary

Each criterion has two independently assessed parts:

1. **The rationale** — how well you justified your choice of source material, including AOI and context
2. **The commentary** — how well you explained the experimentation process and your musical decision-making

You will usually find these two parts point in the same direction. If they diverge — a strong rationale but weak commentary, or vice versa — the mark reflects the balance between them.

The three levels

Part 1: The rationale

Band	What it looks like
Ineffective (1–2)	The choice of stimulus is stated but not justified. No meaningful connection to AOI, context, or research. The examiner cannot tell why this material was chosen or what musical purpose the experimentation serves.
Suitable (3–4)	The rationale makes a reasonable case for the choice. Some connection to AOI and context is present. The justification is sufficient but may lack specificity or depth.
Purposeful (5–6)	The rationale clearly justifies the choice of source material with musical reasoning, connects it to the AOI and context, and refers to research. The motivation for the experimentation is convincing.

Note: a purposeful rationale should justify the choice and give a sense of the motivation for experimenting — but it does not need to predict the outcomes. Research has no direct mark; its value lies in how it informs the rationale and process.

Part 2: The commentary on the experimentation process

Band	What it looks like
Outlines (1–2)	Names what was done without explanation. Reads like a list of actions.
Describes (3–4)	Gives a detailed account of what happened and how. Musical decisions are reported but not explained.
Explains (5–6)	Gives a detailed account including reasons. Connects decisions to musical intentions. Evaluates what worked, what didn't, and why — including negative outcomes if relevant.

What this looks like in practice

The difference between the three levels becomes concrete in single sentences. For **creating**:

Level	Example
Outline	<i>“I added some chords.”</i>
Describe	<i>“I included G7 and C7 chords in the piano part at the chorus.”</i>
Explain	<i>“To adapt to a jazz style, I added the seventh chords G7 and C7 in the chorus, since these are characteristic of the harmonic language of the style.”</i>

For **performing**:

Level	Example
Outline	<i>“I tried playing it faster.”</i>
Describe	<i>“I increased the tempo, putting more weight on the accents.”</i>
Explain	<i>“To make it sound funkier, I tried increasing the tempo and pushing the off-beat accents, since this rhythmic emphasis is central to the performing practice of the style.”</i>

Evaluation and reflection

Effective evaluation appears throughout the commentary — not just at the end. It includes:

- Observations about what could have been done differently
- Reasoning that motivates the next experiment
- Honest negative assessments if the experiment did not produce the intended result

A negative evaluation that is clearly expressed and used to inform subsequent decisions is as valuable as a positive one.

The role of illustrations

Screenshots, score extracts, and other graphic elements should clarify and amplify the commentary. If an image appears without explanation, it does not earn marks. Visual material must be connected explicitly to the musical decisions being described.

Criteria B & D: Practical Experiments

Each criterion has two independently assessed parts:

1. **Treatment of source material** — the degree to which the musical ideas have been developed
2. **Evidence of musical decision-making** — the quality of the practical choices visible or audible in the experiments

The four levels

Part 1: Treatment of source material

Band	What it looks like
Reiterates (1–2)	Source material is reproduced largely unchanged. Limited or no development of musical ideas. The experiment cannot be distinguished from the original.
Recreates (3–4)	Source material is rearranged or reformulated. The ideas are recognisable but not meaningfully transformed. Development is formulaic.
Adapts (5–6)	Source material is adjusted and developed into new contexts. Personal musical decisions are evident. The result is purposeful and shows informed engagement with the material.
Transforms (7–8)	Source material is fundamentally changed into something new with a distinctive identity. The development is imaginative and the result is compelling as a piece of music-making in its own right.

Part 2: Practical evidence of musical decision-making

Band	What it looks like
Superficial (1–2)	Little evidence that informed decisions were made. Changes are surface-level (tempo, key, instrumentation) without deeper musical engagement.
Inconsistent (3–4)	Some evidence of decision-making. Certain sections show musical awareness; others do not.
Proficient (5–6)	Clear and consistent evidence of informed decisions. The choices are purposeful and their effect on the music is evident.
Compelling (7–8)	Musical decision-making is resourceful and imaginative throughout. The decisions give the work a distinctive voice.

Criterion D specifically: the audio as evidence

For performing experiments, the audio recording is the primary evidence of the practical experiments. The commentary explains the decisions; the audio must make those decisions audible. If the performing decisions are not discernible in the recording — even if the commentary claims them — the mark for the practical evidence will be limited.

The commentary for performing experiments should focus on performing aspects (technique, interpretation, articulation, stylistic elements) rather than compositional or arranging decisions. If a performing experiment is primarily about rewriting the music rather than about how it is executed, it is not a performing experiment.

The Glossary

Key terms from the IB Experimenting component, as defined in the Examiner Instructions.

Term	Definition
Musical analysis	Thoroughly deconstructing music to determine the use and manipulation of identified musical elements, compositional devices, and the relationships between them; evaluating how the findings relate to context, genre, and style
Commentary	An explanation of the process of experimenting with and developing music, with specific reference to the details of the chosen musical excerpts
Musical material	Any musical idea, complete or not, independent or not — such as motifs, sounds, loops, and so on; includes primary and secondary sources used to derive musical and extra-musical findings
Rationale	An exposition of the reasons or objectives for research into or practical work related to musical processes, including justifications for decision-making and consideration of the implications of those decisions on the process
Musical findings	Any information found in research by looking at the actual music — studying scores, performances, recordings
Experiment	Doing something to see what happens as an outcome. The nature of experimenting is candidates doing something to see what happens. Candidates justify the focus of their experimentation in the rationale (A and C), which informs the examiner when assessing the practical work (B and D)

Experimenting: Common Mistakes

1. Presenting instead of experimenting

The problem: A student submits what is essentially a free personal composition or a polished piece, framed as an “experiment.”

Experimenting with Music is not a free creating task. That work belongs in Presenting Music. The Experimenting component requires you to start from a specific stimulus, make decisions about how to develop it, and document that process of development across a series of three linked experiments. The experiments are assessed on how musical ideas evolve from the source material — not on the quality of the final product as an independent piece.

A submission that presents a refined, complete composition without making the stimulus visible, or without showing the development across experiments, cannot demonstrate the treatment of source material that Criteria B and D require.

2. Three disconnected experiments instead of a progressive series

The problem: Three separate experiments that each start fresh, rather than a series where each one grows from what the previous one discovered.

The three creating experiments should form a progressive series: each one builds on the findings of the last. The same applies to the three performing experiments. Experiments that are simply three different approaches to unrelated stimuli do not allow the development of ideas to be traced across the submission.

Submissions where the commentary explicitly connects each experiment to the next — explaining what the current experiment discovered and how that motivates the subsequent one — consistently achieve higher marks in Criteria A, B, C, and D.

3. Commentary that lists without explaining

The problem: Commentary reads as a diary of events rather than an analysis of decisions.

There is no mark specifically for research, and no mark for effort. Marks are awarded for the quality of explanation of the musical decision-making. The difference between the mark bands comes down to a single shift:

- **Outline:** *“I added some chords.”* ← States what happened. No musical reasoning.
- **Describe:** *“I included G7 and C7 chords in the piano part at the chorus.”* ← Reports what happened with detail. Still no reasoning.
- **Explain:** *“To adapt to a jazz style, I added G7 and C7 chords in the chorus, since dominant seventh chords are characteristic of the harmonic language of the style.”* ← Connects the decision to the musical intention.

The same pattern applies to performing commentary:

- *“I tried playing it faster”* → outline
- *“I increased the tempo, putting more weight on the accents”* → describe
- *“To make it sound funkier, I pushed the off-beat accents and increased the tempo, since this rhythmic emphasis is central to the performing practice of this style”* → explain

The commentary for **performing** experiments should focus on performing decisions: technique, articulation, stylistic interpretation. If most of the commentary describes compositional or arranging decisions rather than how things were executed in performance, the performing experiment has not been adequately addressed.

4. Performing experiments that are actually creating experiments

The problem: A student arranges or rewrites the music, then performs the result, and calls this a performing experiment.

Arranging the music, reharmonising it, or producing a new version before performing it is a creating activity. The performing experiment is assessed on what happens in the performance itself — the techniques, interpretations, and stylistic choices applied in execution. Preparation that involves creating new material is valid context, but it is not the central evidence for Criteria C and D.

Similarly, multi-tracking — recording multiple separate layers and combining them — is a production and arranging technique. The performing experiment must be visible in what each layer does idiomatically; layering parts together is not in itself evidence of performing experimentation.

5. Surface-level “transformation”

The problem: A musical change is presented as stylistic transformation when it only touches surface features.

Changing the time signature from 4/4 to 3/4 to create a “waltz” is not a stylistic transformation if the rhythmic emphasis, characteristic accompaniment patterns, phrasing, and performing conventions of the waltz are not addressed. The word “waltz” appears in the framing, but the generic features of waltz are not demonstrated in the music.

Transformation requires that the musical ideas themselves are fundamentally changed — that the result has a distinctive new identity rooted in specific, researched stylistic features. Generic surface features (changing tempo, key, or meter) without engagement with the deeper conventions of the target style typically achieve only the recreating or adapting band.

6. AOI 4 as a default for electronic music

The problem: Any music that uses electronic instruments or production is classified as Area of Inquiry 4.

AOI 4 focuses on music in which electronic or digital technology is central to how the music is *created, performed, or produced* — where the technology is a defining characteristic of the music’s identity and methods. A pop song that uses electric guitar, synthesiser, or a DAW is not automatically AOI 4. If the music’s primary relationship to the four areas is sociocultural expression (AOI 1), aesthetic performance (AOI 2), or dramatic/entertainment function (AOI 3), that is its area of inquiry regardless of the instruments used to make it.

Misclassifying music as AOI 4 simply because it involves electronics affects the quality of the rationale (Criteria A/C) and can limit how well the conventions of the actual style are understood and applied.

7. Personal context

Personal context does not apply in this component. The Experimenting component requires investigation of music from *local or global* contexts — music that is less familiar to the student. Selecting music from the student’s own cultural background and immediate personal experience is not aligned with the component’s requirements.

8. MuseScore as a primary source

MuseScore is an online library of user-submitted transcriptions, not a repository of authenticated scores. Transcriptions on MuseScore have no guarantee of accuracy and cannot be cited as authoritative sources. If you use MuseScore to find material, verify the score against a reliable primary source before using it as evidence.

Citing a MuseScore transcription as if it were the original published score undermines the credibility of any analysis based on it.

9. Performing someone else’s existing adaptation

The problem: A student finds a jazz arrangement of a pop song on YouTube, learns it, and performs it as their performing experiment.

This is reiterating an existing adaptation, not experimenting. The student is reproducing someone else’s musical decisions, not making their own. The entire purpose of the performing experiment is to document the student’s own process of developing musical ideas — which requires that the decisions originate with the student.

Presenting Music

Presenting: What Each Level Means

The Presenting rubrics list *possible characteristics* alongside the mark bands, but the subject guide does not define them. This page explains what each band looks like in practice, criterion by criterion.

Criterion A: Programme Notes

This criterion assesses how well the programme notes address all four areas of inquiry and justify the choices made. The criterion has two parts, marked independently then combined holistically:

1. Whether all four areas of inquiry are addressed
2. How well the choices are justified

A structural requirement applies to the first part: if fewer than four areas of inquiry are addressed, achievement is capped at marks 1–2 for that aspect of the criterion. All four must be present.

The three levels of justification

Band	What it looks like
Ineffective / Rudimentary (1–2)	Programme notes list or outline selections without linking them to specific areas of inquiry. Or: fewer than four AOIs are addressed at all. The reader cannot tell why this music was chosen or what it has to do with the stated area.
Suitable / Inconsistent (3–4)	Programme notes describe selections and make some attempt to connect them to areas of inquiry, but the connection is not always convincing or consistent. The AOI is identified but the justification is partial, vague, or incorrect for one or more pieces.
Relevant / Purposeful (5–6)	Programme notes explain selections and purposefully link each one to its area of inquiry with musical reasoning. Every AOI is addressed, identified, and justified. The connection between the music and the area is clear and supported by musical detail.

Ian's three-step structure

There are three distinct requirements for achieving in the upper mark band of Criterion A:

1. **All four AOIs exist** — every piece has an area of inquiry assigned to it
2. **Each AOI is codified** — the student explicitly states which AOI each piece belongs to (it is not enough to write about AOI themes generally without labelling which piece is which)
3. **Each is explained** — the student says *why* and *in what way* this piece belongs to that AOI, with musical reasoning

A programme that names all four AOIs but does not label which piece belongs to which is not addressed. A programme that labels all pieces but does not explain the connection will describe, not explain. All three steps are necessary for the upper mark band.

The role of scores and notation

The programme notes are where scores, screenshots, and other visual representations of the creating should appear. The absence of any notation for a created work is self-limiting for Criterion A — in practice it is very unusual to achieve above mark 3 without notation of created work appearing in the programme notes. If the work is music technology, DAW screenshots count as notation provided they are annotated and explained.

Questions that separate a 4 from a 5–6

- Does the student justify *why* each programme choice is linked to its area of inquiry, or simply state that it is?
- Is the musical content discussed accurately and with proficiency?
- Are any scores, screenshots, or visual representations relevant to the claims being made, or decorative?

Criterion B: Musicality and Technical Proficiency of Created Works

This criterion assesses the creating works in two parts:

1. **Conventions** — how well the student applies the creating conventions of the chosen style
2. **Technical proficiency** — how well the student demonstrates technical command of the compositional or production craft

The four levels

Criterion B: Musicality and Technical Proficiency of Created Works

Band	Conventions	Technical proficiency
Rudimentary (1–3)	Approximates — imitates surface features without demonstrating understanding of what makes the style distinctive; or conventions are absent or incorrect	Rudimentary — notation is unplayable on the instrument(s) specified; instrument ranges or articulation are disregarded; very short duration; no dynamic or expressive markings; or computer-generated output with no musical decision-making visible
Inconsistent (4–6)	Exhibits — applies recognisable conventions of the style, but formulaically; the style is identifiable but lacks personal musical choices	Inconsistent — some sections show control, others do not; ranges and articulation are mostly correct; some expressive marking present
Competent (7–9)	Realizes — conventions are correctly and convincingly applied; the work is stylistically faithful and shows genuine understanding	Competent — the work is idiomatic for the instrument(s) or medium; playable, balanced, and musically coherent; notation provides sufficient detail for performance
Excellent (10–12)	Synthesizes — combines and blends existing elements, styles, or techniques to create something genuinely new; a personal musical voice is evident	Excellent — exceptional technical command throughout; nuanced, idiomatic, and fully communicative

Marking from the score, not the recording

For created works, the score (or notation/screenshot) is the primary evidence. The quality of the recording of the creating work does not substitute for what the notation shows. A brilliant professional recording of a technically weak composition should be marked according to the composition, not the recording. Conversely, a technically accomplished score that was recorded poorly is marked on the composition's merits.

What “idiomatic” means: writing that matches the musical capabilities, accepted timbres, performance styles, technical possibilities, and appropriate ranges of the instrument. A piano piece that could not be played by a pianist (e.g., requiring three hands, or writing in an impossible register in a way that is not stylistically intentional) lacks idiomatic integrity.

Duration and evidence

A very short creating submission limits the evidence available. Two minutes of creating is not sufficient to demonstrate consistent technical proficiency or sustained musical development. In practice:

Presenting: What Each Level Means

- Two compositions of approximately three minutes each, or three compositions of approximately two minutes each, represents a typical submission
- A 20-second music technology piece followed by brief fragments does not provide enough evidence for the upper mark bands

What counts as “creating” versus “arranging”

The music guide states that *arranging and remixing do not feature in this component and will not be accepted for assessment*. However:

- A student who begins with their own piece and then arranges it for orchestra — if the orchestration demonstrates musical decision-making and is the student’s own work — is still creating
- A student who quotes existing material and then develops it through variations is creating, provided the score makes clear what was done and what is original
- A student who transcribes another composer’s piece into a different instrumentation with no further development is not creating — it is transcription
- The test is whether the work is *the student’s own*, whether there is evidence of musical decision-making, and whether there is something identifiably personal in the result

For music technology compositions: all parts must be MIDI entered or performed and recorded by the student. Sampled parts and drum loops are only acceptable if the teacher can verify they were performed or recorded by the student.

Criterion C: Musicality and Technical Proficiency of Performed Works

This criterion assesses the performed works in two parts:

1. **Performing practices** — how well the student applies the performing conventions of the chosen style
2. **Technical proficiency** — the level of mastery demonstrated in delivery

The four levels

Band	Performing practices	Technical proficiency
Rudimentary (1–3)	Approximates — imitates the style at surface level without applying its specific performing practices; or practices are incorrect or absent	Rudimentary — significant and consistent intonation problems; unstable rhythm; tone quality prevents assessment; or recording is so short (e.g. one minute) that there is insufficient evidence

Band	Performing practices	Technical proficiency
Inconsistent (4–6)	Transmits — applies recognisable performing practices of the style; technically accurate but may lack expressive depth or personal interpretation	Inconsistent — some technical control, some hesitation; uneven intonation across the performance; some sections competent, others weak
Competent (7–9)	Shapes — performing practices are present and musically convincing; minor errors do not affect the overall impression; fluency and command of musical elements are evident	Competent — the performance demonstrates mature command; the music is delivered with appropriate style, expression, and control throughout
Excellent (10–12)	Personalizes — the performance expresses a distinctive personal voice; performing practices are fully integrated and expressive, not merely technically correct	Excellent — compelling technical and musical achievement; everything in the performance is working together

Intonation

Intonation is part of technical proficiency and should be assessed with the same weight as all other technical elements. A technically fluent performance with consistently poor intonation cannot be considered competent.

Short recordings

A recording of approximately one minute is insufficient to demonstrate technical proficiency or performing practice across the required demands of the style. A short performance is self-limiting in much the same way that a short creating work is — there is simply not enough evidence for the upper mark bands.

Ensemble submissions and audibility

The student's individual contribution must be clearly audible for their work to be assessed individually. Where the student cannot be heard distinctly:

- If the whole submission is ensemble: the examiner must mark the quality of the ensemble as a whole. This is self-limiting unless the ensemble is of high quality
- If the submission is mixed (some solo, some ensemble): an extract (up to 2 minutes) demonstrating the student's individual part is required for the ensemble portion
- Microphone placement close to the student, or use of small ensembles, significantly increases the likelihood of a fair individual mark

Not marking the accompanist

Where an accompaniment is present — another instrumentalist, vocalist, or technology — the accompaniment is not assessed. For a duo where both parts are musically equal and interdependent (e.g., a violin and piano sonata), the examiner considers the two parts as an ensemble and marks accordingly. The focus remains on what the assessed student is doing.

Criterion D: Musical Communication

This criterion assesses the overall effectiveness of the student's musical communication across all three roles: as researcher, creator, and performer. It is assessed holistically — stronger work in one role compensates for weaker work in another.

Musical communication includes: musical intentions, expression, interpretation, notation, and audio quality.

The four levels

Band	What it looks like
Ineffective (1–2)	Communication does not allow full understanding of the work across the roles; the areas of inquiry are not addressed; audio quality prevents assessment; or there is minimal evidence across the roles
Suitable (3–4)	Communication is present but may not allow full understanding across all chosen works; some roles are more successfully communicated than others
Competent (5–6)	Communication is effective across the different roles and allows full understanding of the chosen works; the AOIs are addressed and recognisable in the submission
Compelling (7–8)	Communication is compelling across different roles; the submission as a whole creates a strong, coherent impression; the listener wants to hear it again

The natural starting point

When the areas of inquiry are clearly addressed in the programme notes, and the recording quality is adequate, Criterion D tends to fall in the 5–6 range. This is not a prescribed mark, but the accumulated experience of examiners across many sessions. A submission where everything is working — AOIs addressed, notation present, recording clear, musical intentions discernible — is typically competent, meaning a mark of 5 or 6.

To reach 7–8 (compelling), the creating *and* the performing both need to be outstanding. If one role is very strong and the other is moderate, the competent band is the likely outcome.

Compelling vs. competent: A competent submission is one where everything is in order. A compelling submission is one that commands attention — something that you want to hear again, something that demonstrates a distinctive musical personality across all the roles.

Do not double penalise

Criterion D is assessed across the roles. If technical limitations in the performing have already reduced the mark in Criterion C, those same limitations should not be described again as a failure of musical communication in Criterion D. The criterion D mark should reflect whether the musical communication across the *whole submission* is effective — not repeat observations already made in B and C.

The Glossary

Definitions from the Examiner Instructions that shape how examiners read Presenting submissions.

Term	IB definition
Technical proficiency	The level of mastery of musical skills that allows a candidate to access, create, perform, produce or reproduce musical material to a required standard. Technical proficiency enables candidates to interpret musical material and express themselves eloquently on a chosen instrument, voice, or medium.
Expression	The use of techniques, musical dynamics and personal knowledge to enhance and express an artistic message. Communication of the intent and purpose of music in an informed and mature manner, informed by extra-musical and musical information combined with a personal and imaginative musical voice.
Idiomatic use of instruments	Writing and arranging in a way that matches the musical capabilities, accepted timbres, performance styles, technical possibilities and appropriate ranges of the instrument.
Interpretation	Informed by the original context of the chosen work, but may also be inspired by the interpretations of others. Shaped by continued practice, critical research, and engagement with the music.
Notation	A representation of sound or performance instructions. Forms of notation should be effective and appropriate to the chosen style — including graphic scores, numeric notation, tablature, sargam, solfège, screenshots, technology notes, staff/stave notation, or other forms of visual evidence. To effectively represent the music, choose the form appropriate to the musical conventions of the style.

Presenting: What Each Level Means

Term	IB definition
Programme notes	Supplement music selected for presentation by introducing chosen works, justifying choices, and enhancing understanding. Programme notes serve as a <i>holistic summary</i> , rather than a detailed discussion of individual works.
Accompaniment	One or more parts to support the soloist. Choices of accompaniment must be justifiable in keeping with the performing conventions of the chosen style. Backing tracks of accompaniments not conceived as such are strongly discouraged.
Ensemble	Any musical group comprising three or more members contributing in various capacities (the roles are not those of soloist with accompaniment).
Practices (musical)	Include, but are not limited to, approaches and conventions, beliefs and ideas, and genres and styles of music-making. Musical practices are continuously evolving.

Presenting: Common Mistakes

These are the problems that appear most consistently across Presenting submissions. Understanding them concretely is more useful than reading the rubric descriptors alone.

1. AOIs that exist but are not linked

The problem: Areas of inquiry are named — on the teacher form, in headings, or in passing — but the programme notes never explain the connection between the AOI and the specific piece.

This is the most common way to fail the upper band of Criterion A. The issue is not that the student chose the wrong AOI; it is that the link is asserted rather than demonstrated.

What the examiner needs: Three distinct things, in order:

1. **Existence** — all four AOIs appear in the programme notes
2. **Codification** — each piece is explicitly labelled with its AOI (“This piece is Area of Inquiry 2 because...”)
3. **Explanation** — the student explains *in what way* and *why* the music belongs to that area, with musical reasoning

A programme that lists four AOIs at the start and then never mentions them again in relation to individual pieces has done step 1 but not steps 2 or 3. A programme that labels each piece correctly but says only “I chose this because it is dramatic” has done steps 1 and 2 but not step 3.

The mark difference this makes: Meeting all three steps reliably puts the criterion in the 5–6 band. Stopping at step 2 lands in the 3–4 band. Stopping at step 1, or not addressing all four AOIs, limits the mark to 1–2.

Presenting only: Presenting is the only component where all four areas of inquiry must be addressed. There is no requirement to cover contexts (personal, local, global); that framework applies to Exploring and Experimenting, not Presenting. If a student mentions contexts in their programme notes, it is not wrong, but it uses word count that could be spent on more relevant content.

2. Treating “creating” as arrangement or transcription

The problem: A student takes an existing piece and writes it out for different instruments, or produces a MIDI mockup of a score without making any musical decisions of their own. This is transcription. The music guide states that *arranging and remixing do not feature in this component and will not be accepted for assessment*.

What counts and what does not:

Acceptable	Not acceptable
Composing an original work	Transcribing a piece for different instrumentation
Writing variations on a quoted theme (provided the score shows clearly what is original)	Changing tempo, key, or instrumentation of an existing piece without further development
Orchestrating your own existing work (the orchestration itself demonstrates musical decision-making)	Producing a MIDI file of an existing score and calling it a composition
A music technology composition where all parts are MIDI entered or performed by the student	Using a pre-made drum loop or sample without teacher authentication that it was created by the student

Why this matters: If there is no evidence of the student’s own musical decision-making, the examiner cannot assess creating conventions or technical proficiency in composition. A very polished recording of an arrangement of another composer’s work is not evidence of the student’s creating ability. The mark is for the student’s compositional decisions, not for what someone else composed.

The score is primary evidence for creating. Examiners are asked to mark the composition from the score, not from the quality of its recording. A brilliant recording of a weak composition should be marked as a weak composition. A thoughtful, technically accomplished score with a mediocre recording should be marked as a thoughtful composition. Do not let recording quality substitute for compositional evidence.

3. Not being audible in ensembles

The problem: A student performs in a large ensemble and submits the ensemble recording, but their individual contribution cannot be heard clearly enough to be assessed.

When the examiner cannot identify what the student is doing, they can only mark the ensemble as a whole. This is self-limiting: if the ensemble is of average quality, the student gets a mark reflecting the ensemble’s average quality, regardless of their individual level.

How this plays out:

- **Whole submission is ensemble:** an extract of approximately 2 minutes showing the student's own part is required. Without this, the mark cannot reflect the student's individual level
- **Mixed submission (some solo, some ensemble):** extracts are expected for ensemble portions; the solo works provide direct evidence of individual level
- **Small ensemble or clearly audible part (e.g., a prominent cello solo in a trio):** the individual contribution may be identifiable without an extract

Practical implications: A student who is a very capable performer but submits only a large ensemble recording with no extract may receive a lower mark than a less technically able student who submits clear solo recordings. The issue is evidential, not musical.

Ensemble = three or more performers in various capacities (not soloist with accompaniment). A violin and piano duo where both parts are equally important is treated as an ensemble for assessment purposes.

4. Submissions that are too short

The problem: The student submits very little creating or performing material, which makes it impossible for the examiner to assess technical proficiency or musical development at the upper mark bands.

For creating: The submission total is a maximum of 6 minutes. Two compositions of approximately 3 minutes, or three of approximately 2 minutes, provides sufficient evidence. A 20-second music technology piece, or a single 2-minute composition, does not provide enough evidence to demonstrate consistent stylistic understanding and technical control. A very short submission is self-limiting.

For performing: The maximum is 12 minutes. A recording of approximately 1 minute is insufficient to demonstrate technical proficiency — there is simply not enough evidence for the examiner to assess intonation, rhythm, tone quality, and style across the work. A 1-minute performance approximates by default because the evidence is too thin.

The word count works the same way: 600 words is the maximum for programme notes. Under-use is self-limiting if something is consequently missing. However, a very concise set of notes that explains everything clearly and purposefully can still achieve a high mark — brevity is not penalised if the content is complete.

5. Notation that doesn't communicate

The problem: Scores are submitted but they contain no expressive markings, no dynamic indications, no articulation, no phrase markings — just pitches and rhythms. Or, for music technology, a screenshot of the DAW is submitted with no annotation or explanation of what it shows.

The purpose of notation in this component is to be *an effective representation of sound or performance instructions*. If the notation does not communicate what the student intended and how, it cannot evidence compositional decision-making.

What examiners look for in notation:

- Dynamic markings: where things get louder, quieter, and by how much
- Articulation: how individual notes are to be played
- Phrase markings or bowing/breath indications
- Tempo and character markings
- For ensemble writing: that ranges are playable, that the melody can actually be heard through the texture, that the balance of voices is considered

For music technology scores: DAW screenshots alone are limited. The student should annotate them and explain what specific parameters, filters, or effects are doing. Graphic notation showing changes in filters or parameters over time is more communicative than a waveform image. A piano roll view (MIDI data) is more informative than many DAW notation views, which can be inaccurate. Audio waveform screenshots represent sound, not music — they do not communicate compositional decisions.

Notation definition (IB): Notation may take any form appropriate to the style, including graphic scores, numeric notation, tablature, sargam, solfège, screenshots, technology notes, and staff/stave notation. The form matters less than whether it effectively communicates the student’s musical decisions.

6. Criterion D treated as a repeat of B and C

The problem: A student’s performing has clear technical limitations. The examiner marks Criterion C accordingly. They then repeat the same observations in Criterion D — “the musical communication is weak because of the technical limitations in performance.”

This is double penalising. A student who has already received a lower mark in C for technical reasons should not receive a further reduction in D for the same reason.

What Criterion D is actually asking: How effectively does the submission as a whole communicate musical intentions across all three roles — researcher, creator, and performer? It is a holistic picture: do the programme notes, the notation, the recordings, and the overall shape of the submission cohere into something that communicates the student’s musical ideas?

The practical starting point: When the areas of inquiry are addressed in the programme notes and the recording quality is adequate, Criterion D tends to settle in the 5–6 range. The question for 7–8 (compelling) is whether the whole submission — not just one element — creates a genuinely compelling impression. This typically requires both the creating and the performing to be outstanding.

Compelling vs. competent: Competent means everything is in order. Compelling means the listener wants to engage with it again — something distinctive and musically purposeful comes through. It is qualitative, not just technical.

The Contemporary Music Maker (HL)

CMM: What Each Level Means

Component Overview

The CMM is assessed through four criteria, each with a distinct focus. Marks are not awarded for isolated moments but for patterns of evidence across the whole submission.

Criterion	Focus	Max marks
A: Selection of Evidence	Quality, relevance, and variety of evidence documenting the project	8
B: Discussion of the Process	Depth of reflection on challenges, development, and musical choices	12
C: Musicality and Technical Proficiency	Technical skill and musicianship in the identified role	8
D: Organisation and Presentation	Clarity, coherence, and effectiveness of the multimedia presentation	4

Criterion B carries the greatest weight (12 marks) and is consistently the most challenging to do well. **Total: 32 marks.**

A submission is read through three lenses: what were the musical aims, how did the project develop over time, and what was the student's specific contribution.

Criterion A: Selection of Evidence

This criterion assesses the quality and relevance of the evidence selected to document the project. The guiding question is: *Is the evidence appropriate and well-chosen?*

Evidence may include text (slides, written narration), audio (voice-over, recordings), video (rehearsal footage, process clips), scores, DAW screenshots, photos, subtitles, annotations, and bibliography. Evidence of collaboration and research is particularly valued.

Critical distinction: evidence is valued by what it makes visible, not by how much of it there is. A concise and purposeful selection can achieve the highest mark bands. A submission with many scores, recordings, and screenshots can still be limited if those materials do not illuminate the development of the work.

The four levels

Marks	Terminology	What it looks like
1–2	Ineffective / Rudimentary	Minimal, disorganised, or irrelevant. Lacks connection to the project. A few screenshots and text with no clear process visible.
3–4	Sufficient / Suitable	Some relevant evidence but lacks variety or depth. Surface-level documentation. Basic images and descriptions; no development shown.
5–6	Purposeful / Competent	Well-structured and relevant but could be more diverse. Score excerpts, rehearsal clips, DAW screenshots — but key moments underdeveloped.
7–8	Resourceful / Compelling	Comprehensive, diverse, purposeful. Clearly shows the evolution of the project through varied materials: text, video, DAW, performance footage tracing the project's development.

The most common limiter

Students spend most of their presentation on the project plan, treating it as process evidence, and leave little time or space for documentation of what actually happened musically. **The project plan provides context but does not constitute process evidence.** Criterion A rewards documentation of musical development, not planning intentions.

Criterion B: Discussion of the Process

This is the most complex criterion and the one where differences between examiners most often emerge. It assesses the depth and quality of the student's reflection on the process in relation to the stated aims.

Three aspects must be addressed, each assessed separately before a best-fit mark is determined:

Aspect	Progression (low → high)
Challenges and successes	outlines → describes → explains → discusses
Areas for development and strategies for improvement	identifies → distinguishes → investigates → examines
Musical and collaborative choices	states → demonstrates → justifies → evaluates

The four mark bands

Marks	Level	What it looks like
1–3	Rudimentary	Names decisions. Outlines challenges without detail. Lists choices without context. No reasoning provided.
4–6	Reasonable	Provides detail. Describes challenges and how they were addressed. Demonstrates choices through musical material. Some reasoning present.
7–9	Proficient	Explains decisions with clear reasoning. Connects choices to musical intentions. Investigates multiple approaches. Justifies with supporting evidence.
10–12	Excellent	Evaluates decisions by comparing alternatives. Weighs strengths and limitations. Discusses the impact of collaboration and process choices on the musical outcome.

The key distinctions

These terms are not interchangeable synonyms. Each represents a qualitatively different kind of thinking:

State vs Demonstrate: Stating a choice names it. Demonstrating shows it through musical evidence — a score, audio extract, or DAW screenshot. The shift is from words alone to material evidence.

Demonstrate vs Justify: Demonstrating shows what was done. Justifying explains *why* — connecting the decision to the musical intentions. The shift is from description to reasoning.

Justify vs Evaluate: Justifying supports a decision with reasons. Evaluating weighs it — considering alternatives, comparing effectiveness, acknowledging limitations. The shift is from advocacy to appraisal.

What this looks like in practice

The same musical decision written at four levels of depth:

Challenges and successes — melody example:

Band	Example
1–3	<i>“I had trouble composing, finding the right chords, and keeping everything in time.”</i>
4–6	<i>“I had trouble composing a melody that fit my chords. I tested a few options and found one I liked.”</i>
7–9	<i>“At first, I used a major scale, but it sounded too happy for the mood I wanted. I tried switching to a minor scale, which worked better.”</i>
10–12	<i>“I initially wrote a melody in a major scale, but it didn’t match the mood I wanted. I tested different minor scales and found that the natural minor scale lacked tension. Using harmonic minor, I was able to create more expressive leaps while still maintaining the overall feel of the piece.”</i>

Musical choices — compression example:

Band	Example
1–3	<i>“I used compression on the drums.”</i>
4–6	<i>“I used compression to even out the drum levels.”</i>
7–9	<i>“I used compression to even out drum dynamics because some hits were too loud. I adjusted the threshold so the softer hits were still audible.”</i>
10–12	<i>“I experimented with different compression settings. Initially, I used a high ratio, but this made the sound too artificial. I tested a parallel compression technique, which preserved the natural attack while still controlling dynamics. In hindsight, using multi-band compression could have further refined the kick and snare balance.”</i>

What if the project went smoothly?

A smooth process does not prevent high marks — it just changes what the reflection looks like. Even without major obstacles:

- 1–3: States everything worked out, with little or no reflection
- 4–6: Acknowledges the smooth process but describes some minor adjustments
- 7–9: Explains how they refined their work even without major obstacles
- 10–12: Discusses multiple approaches, weighing the strengths and weaknesses of different decisions even in the absence of problems

What if the discussion is entirely verbal — no musical material shown?

Purely verbal commentary, however sophisticated, is significantly limited. To *demonstrate* a choice requires material evidence — a score, audio extract, or DAW screenshot. Without evidence, the response cannot reach the mid or upper bands. A student can state choices verbally at 1–3. To reach 4–6, material evidence must be present.

Applying best-fit across the three aspects

When the three aspects fall in different mark bands:

- Assess each aspect independently
- Identify the dominant mark band (if two out of three aspects are in a higher band, the mark leans there)
- If the evidence is evenly split, consider depth of reasoning and clarity of connection to musical aims

A single instance of higher-level thinking does not determine the mark. What matters is whether that level of thinking is **sustained as the dominant pattern** across the response.

Criterion C: Musicality and Technical Proficiency

This criterion assesses the student's technical proficiency and musicianship in the identified role. Assessment must be grounded in what can be directly observed or heard — not in stated intentions alone.

The four levels

Marks	Terminology	What it looks like
1–2	Rudimentary	Basic execution. Lacks control and stylistic awareness. Ineffective musicianship.
3–4	Sufficient / Inconsistent	Reasonable execution but with noticeable flaws. Sufficient musicianship.
5–6	Competent / Proficient	Generally strong technical skill with minor inconsistencies. Well-structured musical ideas.

Marks	Terminology	What it looks like
7–8	Excellent / Compelling	Highly proficient. Stylistically appropriate, well-developed, compelling musicianship.

What is assessed depends on the role

Technical proficiency is always interpreted in relation to the specific role the student has identified. The most common roles:

Role	What is assessed
Performer	Tuning, phrasing, rhythmic accuracy, dynamic range, control
Composer	Manipulation of melody, harmony, rhythm, form, instrumentation, texture; score quality is also valued
Songwriter	As composer, plus lyricism: language, prosody, expressive content
Producer	Recording quality, audio editing, mixing balance, mastering, sonic coherence, DAW proficiency
Sound engineer	As producer, with greater emphasis on recording and mastering; may include live reinforcement

The role must be identifiable from the evidence. If a student names a role but the submission does not provide sufficient evidence of that role, the examiner must base the assessment on whatever musical evidence is available.

Criterion D: Organisation and Presentation

This criterion assesses how clearly and effectively the submission communicates the project. It is about structure, coherence, and use of media — not about the quality of the content itself.

The four levels

Mark	Terminology	What it looks like
1	Ineffective	Disorganised and difficult to follow. Lacks coherence. Scattered images and text with little explanation.
2	Inconsistent	Some structure but unclear or repetitive. Certain sections hard to engage with.
3	Purposeful	Logical structure, though some areas less engaging. Mix of text, images, and video but relying heavily on one medium.

Mark	Terminology	What it looks like
4	Resourceful	Well-structured, clear, and engaging throughout. Varied media used effectively and integrated smoothly.

Practical considerations

- Presentations significantly under 10 minutes rarely achieve the highest bands — there is insufficient space to document the project with depth
- Submissions that rely exclusively on voice-over slides fall in the lower mark bands
- Variety of media (video, audio, score, images, subtitles) is a positive indicator, but only if it serves clarity and communication
- If the final product is missing, Criterion D will receive the lowest mark
- Content beyond 15 minutes total (or 7 minutes for the final product) must not be assessed

Criterion D assesses how the work is presented, not what it says. Do not allow content quality to influence this mark. There is a known tendency to cluster marks at 3. If the submission is genuinely engaging, varied, and clear throughout, a 4 is appropriate.

CMM: Common Mistakes

1. The project plan treated as process evidence

The problem: The majority of the multimedia presentation is devoted to the project plan — vision statements, timelines, collaborator lists, logistics — with little or no documentation of what actually happened musically.

The project plan provides context for understanding the project’s aims. It is not process evidence. Criterion A rewards documentation of musical development: how the music evolved, what decisions were made along the way, what was tried and revised. Criterion B requires reflection on that development.

A submission dominated by planning material, with minimal evidence of how the music developed, will be limited in both Criterion A and Criterion B regardless of how well-organised or ambitious the plan is. The project plan introduces the project — the majority of the presentation should then show what actually happened.

2. All words, no musical evidence

The problem: The discussion of process is entirely or almost entirely verbal — the student explains what they did, but there are no scores, audio extracts, DAW screenshots, or other material evidence to support the claims.

To *demonstrate* a choice requires showing it through material evidence. This is the threshold between the 1–3 and 4–6 bands in Criterion B. A student can *state* choices at 1–3. To reach 4–6, the choices must be shown through the music itself — not just described in words.

The implication is practical: if a student says “I decided to change the harmonic progression in the chorus,” the examiner must be able to hear or see that decision. Without the audio or score showing it, the claim is unverifiable.

3. Describing collaboration, not reflecting on musical decisions

The problem: Criterion B asks how collaboration shaped musical choices. Students often describe the fact of collaboration (who was involved, what roles were assigned, what the team did) without reflecting on how the collaborative interactions changed the music.

What is being assessed is not the management of the project but the musical consequences of the collaborative process. The progression from lower to higher marks in this strand:

- 1–3: States they collaborated; does not reflect on how it affected the work
- 4–6: Describes the collaboration but focuses on teamwork rather than musical decisions
- 7–9: Explains the impact of collaboration on the creative process
- 10–12: Examines and evaluates how collaboration shaped musical choices and the final outcome

A submission where collaboration is described as logistics (“we met on Tuesdays, X did the recording, Y managed the calendar”) without connecting those interactions to specific musical outcomes cannot achieve the higher marks in this strand.

4. Using higher-level language without higher-level thinking

The problem: A student writes “I evaluated my choices” or “I examined areas for development,” but the content that follows is a basic description or list without the analytical depth those terms require.

Using the vocabulary of a higher mark band does not earn marks for that band. What matters is whether the thinking demonstrated matches what the term requires:

- *Evaluate* means weighing strengths and limitations — comparing alternatives and arriving at a reasoned judgment about effectiveness
- *Examine* means uncovering assumptions and interrelationships — going beyond what happened to ask why it mattered and what it reveals
- *Justify* means providing valid reasons that connect the decision to musical intentions — not just stating the decision

If the surrounding content does not match the level of the term used, the mark reflects the content, not the vocabulary.

5. A non-musical role

The problem: A student identifies their role as concert organiser, logistics manager, or social media coordinator — a role that has no directly assessable musical output.

Criterion C assesses technical proficiency and musicianship in the identified role. A purely logistical or administrative role cannot be assessed musically. If this is the stated role, the examiner must look for any other musical evidence in the submission (e.g., the same student also performed) and assess that instead. Where no musical evidence is present at all, this must be reflected in the mark.

The identified role should align with the musical aims of the project and produce output that can be heard or seen.

6. Multiple students sharing the same presentation

The problem: In collaborative projects, several students use an identical or near-identical multimedia presentation, making it impossible to distinguish individual contributions and roles.

Each student must submit their own individual presentation that explicitly demonstrates their personal process and musical role. While using the same final product is permitted, the process documentation must be individual. A shared presentation cannot be assessed for individual marks.

7. The final product is missing

The problem: A student documents the process thoroughly but does not include the final product in the multimedia presentation.

The final product must be presented to the intended audience as part of the submission, and the video recording of it must be included. If it is absent, Criterion D will receive the lowest mark, regardless of the quality of the process documentation.

8. Insufficient use of the time allowance

The problem: A submission is 5 or 6 minutes long when the maximum is 15 minutes (7 for the final product, 8 for process).

There is no minimum time requirement, but brief presentations rarely provide sufficient evidence for depth across all four criteria. Presentations significantly under 10 minutes will typically leave key aspects of the process underdeveloped. The time allowance is designed to give space for the kind of comprehensive documentation that the higher mark bands require.

Using the full allowance purposefully — not just extending the presentation artificially — is a practical necessity for achieving in the upper bands.

9. The arrangement problem

The problem: A student submits an arrangement without providing the original source material.

When the student's role involves arranging, the original material (score or audio) must be available alongside the arrangement so that the student's own contribution can be assessed. Without the original, it is impossible to evaluate what the student created, adapted, or transformed. If the original is absent, the examiner must look for another assessable role in the submission.